Human Development in Childhood – [Student ID]

1. Introduction

The period between infancy and adolescence is childhood. It is divided into **early childhood (2 to 6 years)** and **middle childhood (6 to 12 years)** (Boyd and Bee, 2019). According to the **biopsychosocial perspective**, the body, mind and the social world interact. This poster discusses biological, psychological and social change during childhood. It also indicates what influences it and makes comparisons between major theories.

2. Biological Development

Physical growth

- The growth is not as rapid as during infancy.
- Children become taller and thinner, and their bodies are more reminiscent of adults (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

Motor milestones

- **Gross motor skills:** running, hopping and climbing then riding a bike.
- **Fine motor skills:** holding a pencil, using scissors, then joined-up writing (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

Brain development

- The brain continues to form connections among nerve cells. This enhances **memory, attention and self-control** (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

Health challenge: physical activity

- Exercise develops strong bones and muscles. It enhances motor and thinking skills as well (WHO, 2024).
- However, **81%** of children between the ages of 11 and 17 years are not physically active all over the world (WHO, 2024).
- So active habits need to start in childhood.

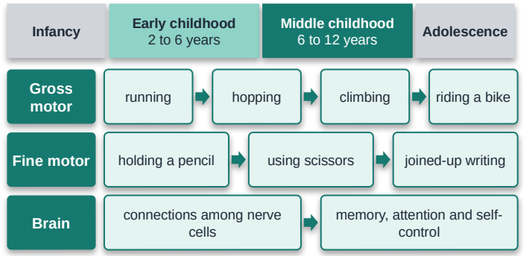


Figure 1. *[MISSING: caption for Figure 1]* (Boyd and Bee, 2019)

3. Psychological Development

Cognitive development: Piaget

- **Preoperational stage (2-7 years):** children make use of words and pretend play. They are egocentric in their thinking and hence cannot view the perspective of another person.
- **Concrete operational stage (7-11 years):** children reason rationally about actual things. They are aware that the same amount of water that was poured into a taller glass remains the same amount (Boyd and Bee, 2019).
- **Critique:** subsequent studies indicate that children usually accomplish these tasks prior to Piaget (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

Emotional and psychosocial development: Erikson

- **Initiative vs guilt (3 to 6 years):** children experiment. Criticism and harshness can lead to guilt.
- **Industry vs. inferiority (6 to 12 years):** skill mastery is a source of pride. Constant failure can lead to less ability on the part of the children (Feldman, 2011).
- Children also get to know that other people think and feel differently. It is referred to as the **theory of mind** (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

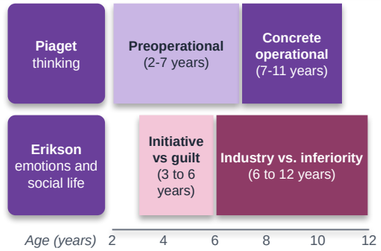


Figure 2. *[MISSING: caption for Figure 2]* (Boyd and Bee, 2019; Feldman, 2011)

Comparing the theories

- Piaget is concerned with **thinking**. Erikson is concerned with **emotions and social life**.
- **Mutual principles:** they are both based on stages of age, both treat the child as an active person, and both accept that the environment influences progress (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

4. Sociological Development

Family

- The initial teachers of rules, values and language are parents.
- Early **secure attachment** is associated with improved peer social skills. A review of 80 samples (4,441 children) found this link (Groh et al., 2014).

Play

- Play transitions to individual to parallel and cooperative play with common objectives (Boyd and Bee, 2019).
- Children also learn to share, take turns and resolve arguments through play.

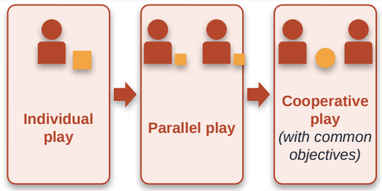


Figure 3. *[MISSING: caption for Figure 3]* (Boyd and Bee, 2019)

School and peers

- School adds new roles, such as pupil, friend and team member.
- During middle childhood, the relationships with friends are founded on **trust and loyalty** (Boyd and Bee, 2019).

5. Key Influences

Bronfenbrenner's bioecological theory

- The child is located within five layers: **microsystem** (family, school), **mesosystem** (connections between them), **exosystem** (work of parents, local services), **macrosystem** (culture, laws) and **chronosystem** (time) (Boyd and Bee, 2019).
- The subsequent one emphasises **process, person, context and time**. Development is caused by regular daily interactions with close individuals (Rosa and Tudge, 2013).

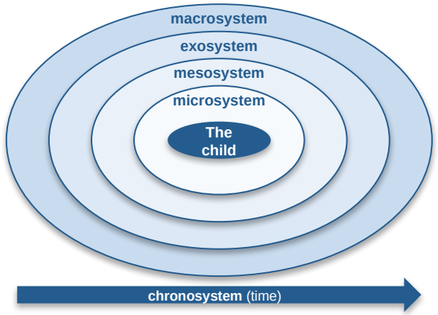


Figure 4. *[MISSING: caption for Figure 4]* (Boyd and Bee, 2019)

Poverty

- In 2024/25, **27%** of UK children lived in relative low income after housing costs. The deep material poverty is **1.9 million children (13%)** (DWP, 2026).
- Brain surface area among children is associated with **family income**. The correlation is the highest in the poorest families (Noble et al., 2015).

Nutrition and weight

- In England in 2024/25, **22.2%** of Year 6 children were obese (OHID, 2025).
- Year 6 obesity was **29.3%** in the most deprived areas, compared with **13.5%** in the least deprived (OHID, 2025).

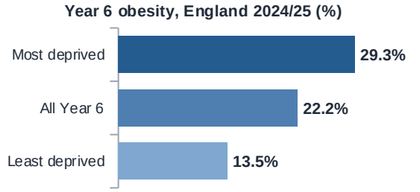


Figure 5. *[MISSING: caption for Figure 5]* (OHID, 2025)

Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs)

- Some of the ACEs are abuse, neglect and living with domestic violence.
- Adults who have **four or more ACEs** are at increased risk of all of the health outcomes examined. The strongest links are with drug problems and violence (Hughes et al., 2017).

Critical point

The majority of this research indicates **interdependence**, rather than causation. Hardship does not hinder the performance of many children (Noble et al., 2015; Hughes et al., 2017).

6. Conclusion

- Childhood is a period of consistent development, more efficient thinking and social world.
- Changes in the biological, psychological and social levels are **interrelated**, rather than independent.
- Piaget, Erikson and Bronfenbrenner may be different in their focus, but they all concur that children are **active** and that the **environment does matter**.
- Development can be damaged by poverty, poor diet and ACEs. It is safeguarded by **caring relationships**.
- **Key message:** look at the whole child in his entirety (Boyd and Bee, 2019; Rosa and Tudge, 2013).

Annotated Bibliography

Reference list	Annotations
Boyd, D.R. and Bee, H.L. (2019). *Lifespan development*. 8th ed. Harlow: Pearson.	Boyd and Bee are renowned authors of developmental psychology, and this is the fundamental book of the text of the module. It describes Piaget, Erikson and Bronfenbrenner, and childhood development, play and friendship. It is a secondary source, and therefore, important concepts were verified with journal articles. It provided a consistent foundation to definitions and stage ages. It had a backing of all parts of the poster.
DWP (2026). *Households below average income: An analysis of the UK income distribution: FYE 1995 to FYE 2025*. [online] GOV.UK. Available at: https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/households-below-average-income-for-financial-years-ending-1995-to-2025/households-below-average-income-an-analysis-of-the-uk-income-distribution-fye-1995-to-fye-2025 [Accessed 1 Nov. 2026].	This is an official report based on accredited government statistics in a survey of 16,299 households in the UK. It is the UK's main source of poverty statistics. It provided the child poverty statistics of 2024/25. There is a level of uncertainty in survey results and a change in methods will impinge on comparisons with previous years. It helped in backing the poverty section.
Feldman, R.S. (2011). *Development across the life span*. Pearson Prentice Hall.	Feldman is a seasoned professor of psychology and this textbook deals with lifelong development. It describes the stages of Erikson in simple language. It also draws parallels between Erikson and Freud. It is of an older nature and thus current evidence was taken up in newer sources. It assisted in verifying the Erikson section.
Groh, A.M., Fearon, R.P., Bakermans-Kranenburg, M.J., van IJzendoorn, M.H., Steele, R.D. and Roisman, G.I. (2014). The significance of attachment security for children's social competence with peers: A meta-analytic study. *Attachment & Human Development*, 16(2), pp.103–136. doi:10.1080/14616734.2014.883636.	This meta-analysis of the most influential attachment scholars combined 80 samples (4,441 children). It discovered safe attachment connections to enhanced peer skills. It has a big sample strength, although the studies present correlation, not causation. It backed the family segment.
Hughes, K., Bellis, M.A., Hardcastle, K.A., Sethi, D., Butchart, A., Mikton, C., Jones, L. and Dunne, M.P. (2017). The effect of multiple adverse childhood experiences on health: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *The Lancet Public Health*, [online] 2(8), pp.356–366. Available at: https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lanpub/article/PIIS2468-2667(17)30118-4/fulltext [Accessed 1 Nov. 2026].	This WHO-associated systematic review combined 37 articles that comprised 253,719 adults. It demonstrates that four or more ACEs increase numerous risks to health. Majority of the research was based on the recollection of childhood by the adults and this could be untrue. It sponsored the ACEs section.
Noble, K.G., Houston, S.M., Brito, N.H., Bartsch, H., Kan, E., Kuperman, J.M., Akshoomoff, N., Amaral, D.G., Bloss, C.S., Libiger, O., Schork, N.J., Murray, S.S., Casey, B.J., Chang, L., Ernst, T.M., Frazier, J.A., Gruen, J.R., Kennedy, D.N., Van Zijl, P., Mostofsky, S., Kaufmann, W.E., Kenet, T., Dale, A.M., Jernigan, T.L. and Sowell, E.R. (2015). Family income, parental education and brain structure in children and adolescents. *Nature Neuroscience*, [online] 18(5), pp.773–778. doi:10.1038/nn.3983.	In this study, Nature Neuroscience researchers scanned the brains of 1,099 youngsters aged 3 to 20. It discovered that family income correlates with surface area of the brain, which is highest with poor families. It was cross-sectional hence could not prove cause. It helped the section of poverty.
OHID (2025). *National child measurement programme (NCMP) annual report, academic year 2024 to 2025, England*. [online] GOV.UK. Available at: https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/national-child-measurement-programme-ncmp-annual-report-academic-year-2024-to-2025-england [Accessed 1 Nov. 2026].	This was an official report in which more than one million kids in England were estimated. It provided rates of obesity and deprivation gap. It only encompasses Reception and Year 6, and body mass index is not a direct indicator of body fat. It was in support of the nutrition section.
Rosa, E.M. and Tudge, J. (2013). Urie Bronfenbrenner's theory of human development: Its evolution from ecology to bioecology. *Journal of Family Theory & Review*, [online] 5(4), pp.243–258. doi:10.1111/jftr.12022.	The authors are Brazilian and American researchers in psychology at the universities. This peer-reviewed article provides an explanation of how the theory of Bronfenbrenner developed into the bioecological model. It is clear in describing process, person, context and time. It is not new research but a theory review. It enhanced the theory comparison in the Key Influences section.
WHO (2024). *Physical activity*. [online] World Health Organization. Available at: https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/physical-activity [Accessed 1 Nov. 2026].	WHO is the most important international health organization. This fact sheet of 2024 enumerates the positive effects of activity among kids and the levels of activity around the globe. Its teenage statistics are not country-specific UK but worldwide and partly outdated. It advocated the physical activity health challenge.

Image References

[MISSING: image references – your content lists no photographs or illustrations. Add the full reference for any image you insert here (images are referenced only, not annotated).]